> others. Beloved-of-the-Gods, King Piyadasi, desires that all should be well-learned in the good doctrines of other religions.[6]

Ashoka was also the first Indian ruler known to have concerned himself with animal rights. In his second tranche of rock edicts (known simply as REs and not to be confused with the earlier MREs), he orders that ‘not a single creature should be slaughtered or sacrificed’, only to qualify this a few sentences later by making an exception for himself: ‘Formerly, in the kitchen of Beloved-of-the-Gods, King Piyadasi, hundreds of thousands of animals were killed every day to make curry. But now with the writing of this Dharma edict only three creatures, two peacocks and a deer, are killed, and the deer not always. And in time, not even these three creatures will be killed.’

Some twelve years later, when Ashoka came to set up the last set of his edicts on enormous polished sandstone pillars, he was even more specific about what creatures could and could not be slaughtered, even to the extent of setting down a most bizarre list of animals, birds, fishes and reptiles that were to be spared, ranging from rhinoceroses, porcupines, lizards, tortoises and certain species of deer to cranes, geese, ducks, doves, mynah birds and parrots, to say nothing of nanny goats, sheep and pigs suckling their young, as well as all quadrupeds which had no economic use or which were not habitually eaten. Cows are not mentioned.

It was initially thought that Ashoka’s proclamations were confined to north and central India, the most southerly being the RE discovered in the 1850s on a hilltop overlooking the rectangular walls of the buried city of Jaugada, on the southern borders of what is now Odisha. Here its royal author reassures his neighbours to the south that he has turned his back on conquest by force and will henceforth conquer by moral force alone. So it was assumed